

I. THE MAN AND HIS WORK

CHAPTER I

LIFE AND BACKGROUND

MOSES, the son of Maimon (the "Rambam"¹ of the Jews, the "Rabbi Moyses" or "Moyses Aegyptius" of the Scholastics and the "Maimonides" of the moderns), was born on the eve of the Passover of the Jewish year 4895 (= 30 March, 1135) in Cordova, the principal city of Moslem Spain. The Jewish settlement in Spain had preceded the coming of the Moslems by many centuries: tradition indeed averred that it was the "captivity of Jerusalem which is in Sepharad" of the prophet Obadiah; but with the coming of the Moslems it enjoyed a freedom and prosperity from which flowered a veritable Renaissance. Maimonides was thus the heir of all that was best both in the tradition of his own people and in the Arab revival of Greek science and philosophy.

He was not destined, however, for a life of ease. Fanatical Berbers from the African desert seized the reins of power. All non-Moslems were offered the alternatives of death or apostasy, and Maimonides, then thirteen years of age, left Cordova with his father and family, and after some twelve years of unidentified wanderings in South Spain found a temporary resting place (1160-65) at Fez in North Africa. The religious persecution which prevailed there, too, drove the family to Palestine. There they stayed for a few months, living at Acre and visiting Jerusalem (where, according to one story, the father, Maimon, died) and Hebron. They settled finally in Egypt, first at Alexandria (1165-66). In Egypt Maimonides lost his brother, a business man with scholarly interests who had supported the family, and in explicit obedience to the Rabbinic injunction not to take money for teaching he turned to the practice of medicine. He made his home in Fostat (Old Cairo), became body-physician to

¹ From the first letters of the words Rabbi Moses ben Maimon.

Saladin's "viceroy" in Egypt, the all-powerful vizier Alfadhel, and his reputation was such that he is said to have been invited by Richard Coeur-de-Lion, then lying at Ascalon, to transfer his services to the English court. But he remained in Cairo and died there in his seventieth year (December, 1204).

In the history of the Jewish people the figure of Maimonides occupies a central place. He represents the highest point reached by the Jewish moral ideal since the time of the Bible, and he combined with that ideal all that was best in the strivings and achievements of contemporary science. Unwavering in his adherence to an historic religion, tenacious in his mastery of the whole field of thought, he synthesized them in a creed which gave philosophic freedom and yet found room for private loyalty and public service. Court physician in a period of political disturbance, he was also the lay head and external representative of his own community; yet he found time, too, to be teacher, friend and adviser of small and great alike, and as his fame spread became the spiritual centre of universal Jewry. His literary achievement was great—indeed, in view of the circumstances in which it was produced, stupendous; but there is a sense of purpose running through the whole which dwarfs even the achievement.

What this purpose was may be summed up briefly. It was to re-interpret Judaism for his generation. To effect this he wrote a series of commentaries to Rabbinic writings, then his own original digest of Jewish law, then the philosophical treatise for which he is especially known to the outside world, the *Guide for the Perplexed*. With this behind him it is not to be wondered at that he dominated the Synagogue; no such genius had appeared within it before or after. But his systematic approach to the problems of an historic way of life in an alien world and a changing civilization brought him beyond the confines of the Synagogue. The problems of religion are universal, and a philosophical treatment of them is universal; too; and Maimonides' treatment made him the guide for the perplexed not only of the Synagogue but also, at one critical period, of the Church.

An attempt will be made later to indicate the nature of Maimonides' influence on scholastic philosophy. But it is

doubtful whether the detail of that influence can be indicated with any precision at all. The idea of personal property in knowledge appears only in the modern acquisitive age, and a Maimonides (as a Thomas Aquinas) would have given as he took, freely and without grudge for the sake of truth. Yet it is worth while indicating something of the general intellectual temper of which Maimonides is so leading a representative.

To the student of the medieval mind there is nothing more striking than its attitude to authority. It not only adhered to received texts (whether the Bible or Aristotle); it concealed its own original contribution under the covers of those same texts. It seems to have delighted in anonymity, to have rejoiced when it could point out that its own new ideas were not so new after all. It dreamt, in fact, of a *philosophia perennis*, a closed universe of truth given once for all and complete in itself.

Of such a closed world modern adventurousness will have nothing: we are always pushing on in search of some new thing; and so long as the new things are new we do not mind if they are discontinuous with the old or with one another. The scholastic age on the other hand loved system, and its characteristic products are the "Summae" of knowledge, the highly compressed and ordered epitomes associated with the names of Aquinas and Maimonides alike. The difference is finally a religious one. *Ours* is a "growing," "emergent," self-evolving world. *Theirs* was "created," the final expression of a completed will.

The universe displayed to us by Maimonides is one in which natural law is supreme. The world is patterned on its creator and its creator is one; nor is he capricious: his monarchy is constitutional. This conception gives the key to a logic for science: the book of nature is a book of law. But since nature is the work of God, natural law is the law of God. Science is thus more than science. It is the gateway to religion.

This idea of the divine reference of the physical universe has sometimes made Maimonides seem a pure rationalist. Rationalist indeed he was, but his rationalism was of a kind which was impregnated perforce by historical and psychological considerations. Two points in particular in the data of his thought emerge as of particular significance, the one, the

detail of Jewish ceremonial law, the other, the phenomenon of prophecy.

It is already a remark of Aristotle that for the detail of religious ceremonies no logical reason can be given. One cannot ask why a specified number of animals (two, three, four) should be required for a sacrifice, as exactly the same question would arise if the number were different; the only explanation possible is an historical one. For Maimonides, the codifier of Jewish law in its entirety, the problem of explanation must often have arisen, and in the third part of the *Guide* he deals with it systematically in a long section treating of the "reasons for the commandments." The mainspring of its argument is significant. Such of the Pentateuchal commandments as appear to us now void of reason had sound reason enough in the environment in which they were originally enacted, and Maimonides plunges into investigations which would now be called anthropological and which touch on many problems of comparative folklore. This treatment, coming as it does after the abstract discussion of the being and attributes of God and the problems of will and design, presses home the point that religion, although its root conceptions may be investigated and deepened by metaphysics, is not itself metaphysics. It is a way of life to be lived.

The second point, the phenomenon of prophecy, is even more important. It meant that Maimonides was definitely committed to a religious view of the world. Succeed though he might in the anthropological explanation of religious observance or in the physical explanation of material fact, it yet remains that for him not Aristotle but Moses is the "man of God." The recognition of this was a gain even from the point of view of philosophy, since it enabled, indeed forced, Maimonides to adopt an independent attitude towards Aristotle; but it meant also that, in grappling with the problems of faith, his attention was directed to those faculties within man which are not narrowly intellectual. For him the study of prophecy thus became a determining factor in the study of the nature of religion, and he is thus the forerunner of the science of the psychology of religion as well as of that of comparative anthropology.

The breadth of these intellectual interests reflects a breadth of human sympathy, and Maimonides' correspondence abounds with touches which suggest not the mere student but the leader and educator. He understood when to yield and when to be firm, when to offer a "Gate of Hope" (the title of the treatise of encouragement he sent to the persecuted Jews of the Yemen), when to display the "Strong Hand" (the title given later to his digest of Jewish law). Yet he remains in memory as the Guide for the Perplexed. Science changes: even the "eternal truths" of mathematics seem to be less eternal than they were; but the problems of the duty and destiny of man and of the being and attributes of God remain as they were eight centuries ago. Many have thought that medieval Aristotelianism has still much to teach us, that modern philosophy took a wrong and disastrous turning with Descartes. But whether or not Maimonides' solutions will stand the test of *our* perplexities, it is the spirit of the *Guide* which is of consequence and which still inspires. We can learn from it the great lesson (and what lesson is more urgent?) that the problems raised by reason should be met by reason.

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Before we come to the detail of the subject so summarily introduced we must turn our attention to two general topics without some understanding of which much of what is to be said will have no meaning. I refer to the cultural environment in which Maimonides found himself and the tradition from which he sprang.

We are accustomed to think of European culture, created by the Greeks and diffused by the Romans, as strangled in the "dark ages" following on the eclipse of the Roman Empire and as revived only in the fifteenth and sixteenth centuries with the recovery of the Greek language, the re-birth of the feeling for beauty, the rise of the sense of individual freedom and the emergence of inductive science. This picture requires some modification. The "dark ages" were not quite so dark as they are sometimes conceived to have been, and the "revival

of learning" began in the era of the early scholastics. True, their interest was eventually theological; but theology for them meant a comprehensive world-scheme in which all knowledge, and all human striving, found its place. Their thinking was metaphysical in the sense that it attempted to refer everything to first principles. But that is what all science tries to do. It is no misnomer therefore to call the great thinkers of the twelfth and thirteenth century scientists. They sought to unify all knowledge in comprehensive formulæ.

One chief difference between the medieval "scientist" and the scientist of to-day lies in the nature of the first principles accepted and in the attitude adopted towards them. The modern scientist has seen the breakdown of too many first principles to accept any as eternal truths. He proceeds inductively, building up slowly on the basis of observed facts. His attitude to his own (or at least to his brother scientist's) first principles is one of hesitation, even suspicion. He looks on them as "working hypotheses" to be modified or changed in the light of further experience. The older scientist, although he too realized that his function was to explain facts, closed the door on fresh evidence too soon. The modern, at least in theory, keeps it always open.

But there is a further and perhaps more interesting difference between them. The medieval thinker aimed at comprehensiveness. He seems not to have been satisfied with anything short of the whole. The modern thinker is more modest and seeks the key not to the universe but to one group of facts within it. He likes to break problems up and resolve them bit by bit. He is not interested (that is, professionally speaking) in the world as a whole, but only in one small corner of it.

Herein lies the traditional distinction between "science" and "philosophy." Both science and philosophy try to discover principles and interpret detail in their light; but whereas science tries to clear up small areas of the world, philosophy aims at the world as a whole. It stands in relation to the various sciences much as each science stands in relation to its particular subject-matter. It is the science which seeks to reduce to scientific unity and order the results of the various sciences.

We are not concerned at the moment with the abstract

possibility of such a "science of sciences," or even with its desirability. It suffices to emphasize one central fact about the medieval philosophers. Far from being, as generally thought, hostile to science, they based their all on science. But it was science *as known to them*, and they took it from the very best source then available, the re-discovered writings of Aristotle.¹

One of the most interesting books in the history of human culture is the volume of the Charters of the University of Paris containing the University rescripts of the thirteenth century.² We can here watch the very gestation of scholasticism. The writings of Aristotle were being re-discovered, and they were anathematized and blessed in dazzling alternation. They represented the new knowledge of the age in much the same fashion as did Darwinism in the last century, and they aroused fear on the one side, enthusiastic championship on the other, as the Wilberforces and the Huxleys of the day were aroused. The details of the controversy are not to the point here, but the fact should be borne in mind. Aristotle did not mean then, as he meant afterwards to Bacon, the dead hand of an abstract and obsolescent traditionalism. He was the very breath of science, the vehicle of new knowledge. He was (as Dante calls him) the "master of those who know."

The story of the bringing of the writings of Aristotle to the western world is one of the romances of history. Their fate was strange indeed from the very first. Hidden in a cellar, so the story runs, by the second generation of his successors in order to elude the interest of a royal book-collector, they remained a prey to worms and damp for a century and a half, till redeemed and "restored," with many an infelicitous conjecture, by a rich Athenian just in time to be seized by the Roman general Sulla in 87 B.C. and brought by him to Rome.

¹ Modern students have traced a strong Platonic strain in the writings even of the Aristotelians, and the text of Aristotle itself was interpreted through the help of the Neo-platonic commentators of the third-sixth centuries. In Jewish thought in particular there was a definite Platonic trend. But these technicalities have no place here.

² Ed. Denifle-Chatelain, 1889. An admirable account of the intellectual atmosphere of the time is to be found in Mandonnet's *Siger de Brabant* (ed. 2, Louvain, 1911). The latest information on the dating of the translations is given by G. Lacombe: *Aristoteles Latinus*, Rome, 1939.

Whether the story is true or not, it would seem to reflect the fact that Aristotle as a philosopher was little read and had little influence on European thought for centuries after his death, and he was known to the later Roman (Christian) world, up to the tenth century at least, only by his logical doctrines as contained in the translations and commentaries of Boethius (A.D. 475-545). From the tenth century on the great effort of western thought was first to complete Aristotle's writings on logic and then to acquire his other writings as well. But Aristotle wrote in Greek, and the knowledge of Greek had died out in the west and was revived there only after the capture of Constantinople, the then centre of Greek civilization, by the Crusaders and Venetians in 1204. The way of direct study was therefore closed.

An indirect way, however, appeared. Constantinople had been open throughout the centuries to the Syriac-writing Nestorian Christians, and they had interested themselves in philosophy and had translated and commented on some of the works of Aristotle as far back as the fifth century. This Syriac storehouse was turned into Arabic at Bagdad during the remarkable cultural Renaissance associated with the Abbasid dynasty, beginning in the eighth century; and it spread all through the Arab Empire—Syria, Palestine, Egypt, North Africa—till it penetrated to Arab Spain. Here, and in the old centres of Greek influence in classical times, Sicily and Southern Italy, the western world went to school again, and its teachers were largely Jewish scholars who had translated the Arabic into Hebrew for the use of their own people, and now translated, or helped to translate, the Hebrew into Latin for the use of Christian students.

The matter so translated was not confined to the text of Aristotle and his commentators. Much original work had been done too, and this, too, through the same chain of Arabic, Hebrew, and Latin, was brought to the notice of the West. The cultural world was unified to an astonishing degree and books spread everywhere and with great rapidity. Nor was distinction made of race or creed. Not only "Moses of Egypt" and "Isaac the Jew," but "Algazel," Avicenna and Averroes were studied everywhere; and the medical canon of Avicenna

became standard in Christian European universities for centuries.

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If the general cultural atmosphere in which Maimonides found himself may be described as Arabized Greek, the Jewish community in which he was born and bred was set fast in a native Jewish tradition. He himself was the son of a "Dayan," and so too, according to the genealogy he himself gives, were his father's grandfather, great-grandfather, and his father before him. The word Dayan, connected with the Biblical Hebrew "din" = judgment, and used occasionally in the Bible, is the normal post-Biblical Hebrew word for "judge," and we have to accustom ourselves to the idea of the existence all over the Arab and Christian worlds of semi-autonomous Jewish communities,¹ largely administered, so far at least as their internal affairs were concerned, in accordance with the principles of Jewish law, by a local Dayan or judge. Jewish law is the law of the Pentateuch as developed both in theory and practice during the long course of Biblical and post-Biblical Jewish history. Its chief literary monuments are the juristic verse-by-verse commentaries on parts of the Pentateuch; the *Mishnah* (second to third century), a systematic compilation of decisions without reference to the Biblical text and arranged in a schematic order of its own; the Talmud (in its two recensions, the Palestinian and Babylonian²), consisting of the *Mishnah*, retained in its own order, together with reports of the discussions on the text of the *Mishnah* held in the schools and the decisions resulting therefrom; and the Responsa, i.e., decisions on specific questions arising in practice and referred to the heads of the Talmudic academies or other leaders of recognized authority.^[3] Thus, Maimon the "Dayan," the father of Maimonides, was the head of the local court of one among many Jewish self-governing communities

¹ See S. Baron's monumental work, *The Jewish Community: its History and Structure* (3 vols., Philadelphia, 1942).

² Generally referred to by the name of the Tractate, preceded by the letters "T.B."

^[3] There will be a fuller description of the literature in another volume in the present series, by Professor Herbert Danby.]

scattered over the medieval world, each responsible (in varying degree) for its own conduct and regulating itself in accordance with the recognized principles of Jewish law.

It is important to understand this as otherwise the significance of much of Maimonides' own work cannot be grasped. Maimonides, too, like his father, was not a mere scholar or a mere philosopher (are there any mere philosophers?), but a man occupied ceaselessly with questions affecting the practical lives of whole communities.

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It is important to remember that these communities, although self-contained, were by no means closed to external influence. In their own way, and even through the medium of their own historic language, they partook of the life of the wider cultural world.

In order to bring this home one may refer again to a great book, this time to a book which is not really a book at all but an encyclopædia, compressed to a fault and written without regard to considerations of style or presentation, but which is yet an unsurpassed source of stimulus and information even to the already instructed: Moritz Steinschneider's *Die hebraeischen Uebersetzungen des Mittelalters und die Juden als Dolmetscher* ("The Hebrew Translations of the Middle Ages and the Jews as Interpreters") (Berlin, 1893). This work gives a picture of the general cultural background of Jewry in the Middle Ages as it is reflected in the translations made by the Jewish scholars of the time into and from both Hebrew and other languages. The material noted covers every subject—not only philosophy, mathematics, medicine, alchemy and the occult sciences, but also literature in its various branches, including even classical poetry (the *Odyssey*!), and medieval romances such as *Amadis of Gaul* and the *Tales of the Round Table*. All these made their way into Hebrew; and although in many cases the manuscripts have long disappeared or are now mouldering on the library shelves, the very fact of the versions having been made attests a width of interest which even to-day would be remarkable. One is made to feel that the Jewish

world was alive, steeped in its own native culture yet in touch too with the best that was known and thought in the outside world as well.

A main interest was, of course, philosophy, and Maimonides was only one, although the most outstanding, of a line of thinkers reaching back at least to Philo of Alexandria and some Talmudic sages and possibly even to the Bible. But we may leave these wider considerations since it is our purpose to study Maimonides not in relation to his predecessors and contemporaries but as he was in himself. This is done most simply by a survey and a brief description of his writings.